

6

CHAPTER



Improving Listening Comprehension

The most important thing in communication is hearing what isn't said.

—Peter Drucker

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Acquiring listening skills
- Learning to identify different aspects of effective listening
- Knowing the 10 thumb rules for good listening
- Grasping techniques for active listening
- Knowing strategies for listening in conversational interaction
- Understanding techniques for listening to structured talks
- Knowing how to become an effective team listener
- Grasping techniques for note taking

6.1 LISTENING COMPREHENSION

Comprehension is the act of understanding or the power of the mind to understand. Listening comprehension is the act of understanding an oral message. As a professional, you have to achieve the ability to comprehend material delivered at relatively fast speed and understand spoken material in standard Indian English, British English or American English. You need intelligent listening skills in situations such as an interview in which you are a candidate, or a group discussion, or a meeting in which you are a participant.

Listening comprehension is an act of understanding an oral message.

Scanning is the ability to locate specific information in a conversation, speech, or presentation whereas prediction is guessing information.

Being a complex process that involves perceiving and interpreting the sounds correctly as well as understanding the explicit and implied meaning of the oral message, listening comprehension includes several skills and sub-skills. These skills include scanning, prediction, speech decoding, comprehending, and oral discourse analysis. The first two skills are similar to scanning and prediction in reading comprehension. Scanning is the ability to locate specific information in a conversation, speech, or presentation whereas prediction is guessing information. The three other skills need some explanation.

6.1.1 Speech Decoding

Speech decoding is integral to listening comprehension. It involves sound perception and recognition, word recognition, and accent recognition.

Sound Perception and Recognition

Decoding of verbal messages requires the ability to perceive and recognise speech sounds and sound patterns accurately as well as the ability to recognise the way sounds combine to form syllables and utterances. The listener has to be attentive to the sounds that he/she hears because any lapse or mistake may lead to miscommunication and misunderstanding. Moreover, a large number of competing sounds from the environment may interfere with concentration and if the listener is not careful, he/she may not perceive sounds accurately.

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Word Recognition

Speech decoding during listening also involves the ability to recognise words accurately, understand definitions of the words and phrases being used, recognise the way words are used in context, and identify discourse markers and attention signals.

Accent Recognition

In order to decode a verbal message, the listener has to recognise stress and intonation patterns. In addition, he/she needs to identify pauses, false starts, hesitations, and turn-taking in a conversation, discussion, or other transactions involving more than one speaker.

6.1.2 Comprehending

Comprehending a verbal message involves the ability to:

- Identify the central theme, main ideas, and supporting details
- Concentrate and understand long speeches
- Identify the level of formality
- Deduce incomplete information
- Decode unfamiliar vocabulary

6.1.3 Oral Discourse Analysis

Oral discourse analysis is the process of identifying relationships among different units within the speech or oral message. It includes critical skills, attitude analysis, and inferential skills.

Oral discourse analysis is the process of identifying relationships among different units within the speech or oral message.

Critical Skills

When you listen to a structured talk, speech, or presentation, you need to analyse it in order to distinguish between relevant and irrelevant information, factual and non-factual information, examples and ideas, and so on. Critical skills are, thus, essential to effective listening comprehension.

Attitude Analysis

You may have to analyse a verbal message in order to understand the speaker's attitude to you and the topic under discussion. This is more important in meetings, discussions, and conferences. Attitude analysis includes the following skills:

- Identifying a speaker's attitude
- Understanding the speaker's attitude
- Evaluating a speaker's attitude

Inferential Skills

Effective listening comprehension involves understanding not only the explicit meaning of a verbal message but also the implicit meaning because the speaker may not speak everything explicitly and clearly. Thus, the listener may have to analyse a verbal message in order to draw inferences and conclusions. This may involve interpreting the non-verbal clues and body language of the speaker.

Progress Check 1

1. Complete the following table in the light of the above discussion about listening comprehension skills:

Listening comprehension skills

Literal skills	
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.Sound recognition

- _____
- _____

Word recognition

- Critical and analytical skills

Complete comprehension of an oral message is more challenging than reading.

Most students who do not have a systematic approach to listening face difficulties in understanding a lecture, a seminar, or a discussion. They suffer from lack of concentration, boredom, ineffective listening, and poor comprehension. As one has to ensure high degree of understanding and remembrance, one should follow a systematic approach to listening. For example, an eminent scholar has to deliver a lecture on a topic relevant to a particular person's studies and career and he/she wants to listen to the professor. In order to take full advantage of this opportunity, he/she needs to follow a systematic listening method and apply appropriate listening strategies for better comprehension.

In order to improve your listening comprehension, some basic tips on good listening need to be followed and active listening techniques should be adopted. In addition, listening strategies should be developed for specific listening tasks such as lecture comprehension, two-way interactions, group interaction, student-teacher consultations, student-student negotiation, seminars, discussion sessions, and so on.

6.2.1 Ten Thumb Rules for Good Listening

Remember the 10 thumb rules for good listening that are listed in Table 6.1. These suggestions can help improve listening effectiveness.

TABLE 6.1 Rules of Good Listening		
1.	Talking	×
2.	Thinking	×
3.	Distractions	×
4.	Mind wandering	×
5.	Putting the speaker at ease	✓
6.	Pre-judgement	×
7.	Patience	✓
8.	Being angry	×
9.	Empathising with the speaker	✓
10.	Taking notes	✓

Stop Talking

Do not talk while listening. One cannot be a speaker and a listener at the same time. The listener should accept his/her role and allow the speaker to talk. He/she should forget about his/her response to the listener and concentrate on the speaker's words.

Stop Thinking

It is not enough for the listener to keep his mouth shut while he/she is listening. He/she has to stop thinking too. He/she cannot listen effectively while thinking. He/she will not be able to focus 100% on what the speaker is telling.

Remove Distractions

In order to focus 100% on the person speaking, the listener should avoid all kinds of distractions. He/she should not create any distractions for himself/herself and should not allow others to interrupt.

Do Not Let Your Mind Wander

One of the main causes of listening inefficiency is the slowness of speech. We can listen faster than the speaker can speak. This lag time may make the listener's mind wander or daydream. This can be avoided by concentrating on each word spoken by the speaker.

Put Speaker at Ease

A conducive environment should be provided to the speaker in order to enable him/her to be at ease. If the speaker is not comfortable, he/she will not be able to speak clearly.

Do not Pre-judge

Give the speaker a chance to complete what he/she has to say. Pre-judgement closes the mind and does not allow you to perceive the speaker impartially. You can make proper judgement only after you have fully comprehended the information.

Be Patient

The speaker should be allowed sufficient time and not interrupted until he/she takes a pause and invites the listener to do so. Patience is the key to good listening. The listener may be in a hurry as he/she has to go somewhere or do something, but good listening demands that he/she listens to the speaker patiently.

Do not be Angry

The listener should control his/her temper while listening. He/she may not like what the speaker is telling, or may completely disagree with his/her point of view but good listening demands that he/she listens to him/her calmly without making any fuss.

Empathise with the Speaker

In order to understand the speaker's perspective and appreciate his/her point of view, the listener should try to put him/her in the speaker's position.

Take Notes

The listener should take notes if he/she wants to keep a record of what was said, and wants to use it at a later stage.

6.2.2 Active Listening Practices

Listening can be passive or active. Passive listening is the process of just absorbing the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement. In passive listening, the listener plays no role. On the other hand, active listening is a dynamic, interactive communicative process in which the listener:

- Pays attention
- Shows interest in the speaker and speech
- Takes note of the speaker's body language
- Avoids distractions
- Responds non-verbally to encourage the speaker

As active listening is interactive and productive, it facilitates proper interaction and produces new understanding. It promotes more effective listener-speaker relationships, and helps us take advantage of opportunities we might miss by being a passive listener. That is why one needs to be an active listener rather than a passive one. Active listening requires conscious efforts on one's part and demands concentration, involvement and responsibility.

Passive listening is the process of just absorbing the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement.

Active listening demands concentration, involvement, and responsibility.

In order to become an active listener, we have to adopt a set of listening practices that may help us understand the meaning of an oral message. Listed below are some guidelines to be followed by an active listener.

Attentive Listening

Unlike a passive listener, the active listener should show interest in the speaker and the speech. He/she should show desire to listen and be interested in what the speaker is telling. He/she should not show non-verbal signals such as audible snoring or rolling eyes that indicate that he/she does not want to listen. His/her posture must reflect his/her interest and his/her body language should indicate his/her keenness to listen.

An active listener would listen to the speaker patiently and carefully and be alert and pay attention while listening. Passive listeners generally listen to others in an unconscious manner without paying attention. By paying attention to both content as well as presentation, we can understand the speaker better.

Using Non-verbal Skills

Appropriate non-verbal skills may be used to indicate interest and understanding. Eye contact should be maintained with the speaker. The speaker should be helped and encouraged by positive body signals such as an occasional nod or a smile. The listener may also send non-verbal signals to indicate comprehension. He/she should also pay attention to the body language of the speaker in order to understand and interpret non-verbal clues for signs of stress, anxiety, excitement, enthusiasm, or boredom. This will help the listener analyse the verbal message in the right perspective.

Active listening includes using non-verbal skills, improving speaker's contribution, asking questions, making clarifications, and analysing an oral message.

Improving Speaker's Contribution

An active listener should take appropriate steps to improve the speaker's contribution. He/she should encourage the speaker to express his/her ideas clearly by indicating understanding and appreciation of his/her point of view.

Asking Questions

Asking questions forms an important part of the listening process as it leads to building up a good rapport between the speaker and the listener. By asking relevant questions we can get the maximum information from a speaker. Moreover, asking questions shows that one is listening and this encourages the speaker. The listener should not wait to be asked and must instead readily ask relevant clarifying questions.

He/she may ask open-ended or closed questions. Open-ended questions provide the speaker with an opportunity to elaborate a point whereas closed questions ask the speaker to be more exact and specific.

Open-ended questions provide the speaker with an opportunity to elaborate a point whereas closed questions ask the speaker to be more exact and specific.

Examples of Open-ended Questions

1. What are the advantages of this deal?
2. What is your personal opinion about the problem?
3. What do you think about this proposal?

Examples of Closed Questions

1. Is this deal acceptable to the management?
2. Are we facing this problem for the first time?
3. Will you accept this proposal?

While asking questions, the listener should not argue or be rigid on a question. The listener should have the liberty to handle the question the way he/she wants. Here are some tips on how to ask questions:

- Questions should be asked at the appropriate points. The speaker should not be interrupted.
- Questions should be chosen carefully. The purpose of asking a question should be to get clarifications and indicate comprehension.
- Simple language should be used to phrase questions.
- Questions should be asked one at a time.
- The listener should wait for an answer patiently.
- The listener should listen carefully to the answer and not jump to conclusions.

Clarifying

Clarify what the speaker is saying by paraphrasing what has been said or summarising one's understanding of the key points. This way the listener can show that he/she is listening carefully and paying attention.

Analysing

As an active listener, one should interpret and analyse what one hears in order to:

- Understand both explicit as well as implicit meaning of an oral message
- Differentiate between ideas, opinions, feelings, and facts, as expressed by the speaker
- Infer the meaning of unfamiliar words from contextual or internal clues
- Draw inferences and conclusions from the speech

6.2.3 Listening in Conversational Interaction

We may have to listen during two-way interactions that may include informal conversations, academic interactions, student-teacher consultations, student-student negotiation, job interviews, and so on. Listening plays a key role in these communicative situations as the output of listening in all these situations is to make considered oral responses. We need to develop effective listening strategies for these communicative situations.

The following suggestions can help improve listening effectiveness during face-to-face conversational interactions:

Listen for Conversational Signals

During a conversation, discussion, or other transaction involving more than one speaker, every participant has to take his/her turn at the appropriate moment. Many a time nobody is there to indicate this turn, or prompt or invite the participant to do so. Each participant has to look out for conversational signals indicating the possibility of starting his/her turn so that he/she is able to take a turn at the appropriate moment.

Listening in conversational interaction involves looking out for conversational signals, evaluating, labelling carefully, using attention signals, and adjusting the pace of listening.

Evaluate

While listening to professional and administrative requirements involving requests, suggestions or instructions, the listener should evaluate what he/she listens to in order to make a mental commentary and develop a line of thought. He/she has to determine necessary action as the output is to perform some physical activity, make an oral response, impart or solicit information, and so on.

Be Careful While Labelling

Whenever a listener hears someone for the first time, he/she starts forming impressions about him/her. These impressions about the background, nature, qualities, social standing, character of the speaker may be true or false. As these impressions lead to changes in the listener's behaviour towards the speaker, he/she should be careful while forming such impressions.

Use Attention Signals

In order to indicate that the listener is participating actively in a conversational interaction, he/she must use appropriate attention signals. These attention signals could be receptive expressions and utterances such as 'oh yes', 'yes', 'fine', 'of course', 'well', 'ok', 'that's fine', 'no problem', 'really', 'oh no', or just informal grunts such as 'uhuh's', 'mm's', 'un-hum', and so forth.

Adjust Your Pace of Listening

As mentioned before, the speed at which we listen is faster than the speed at which we can speak. This time lag may prove boring and lead to a lack of concentration, which may result in poor listening comprehension. So, we should adjust our pace of listening by reviewing what the speaker is saying during this lag time. Moreover, while the listener waits for the speaker's next idea, he/she should concentrate on the implications of what the speaker is talking about.

Work Hard at Listening

Most of us are really not good listeners. Thus, we have to work hard to become good listeners. Every chance to listen to someone provides us an opportunity to learn something. We must be actively involved in all communication and try to make every listening experience a memorable learning experience.

Progress Check 2

1. Which of the following is not an effective listening strategy for two-way interactions?

- (a) Labelling
- (b) Listening for conversational signals
- (c) Too many informal grunts
- (d) Making social judgements
- (e) Using attention signals
- (f) Carrying on mental commentary
- (g) Using receptive expressions and utterances
- (h) Increasing speed of listening

6.2.4 Listening to Structured Talks

In order to understand a structured talk (i.e., lectures, seminar talks, presentations, speeches, oral reports, and so on) or any other formal oral discourse, we require effective listening strategies that help us in comprehending the subject-content and language patterns of the oral message. These techniques include pre-listening analysis, predicting, use of background knowledge, intensive listening, and ability to understand the links between different parts of speech. In order to become an effective listener, we need to learn and polish these listening techniques.

Pre-listening Analysis

Pre-listening analysis includes determining the purpose of listening and knowing the speaker or presenter.

Determining the Purpose

The most important aspect of pre-listening analysis is determining what needs to be achieved by listening to the speaker. Does the listener want to listen to the speaker to get a broad understanding of a topic of his/her interest? Does he/she intend to obtain specific information? Does he/she want to be aware of the opinions and reactions of the speaker to a specific situation or problem? Does he/she want to understand specific instructions? Whether his/her purpose is to get facts or opinions, understand attitude or perspective, he/she must have a clear idea of what he/she wants to remember at the end of the conversation/talk/lecture/speech/presentation/seminar/workshop.

Listening to structured talks involves determining the purpose of listening, knowing the speaker, guessing the expected information, using background information and intensive listening techniques, and comprehending the logical links between different parts of presentation.

Knowing Your Speaker

The second essential aspect in pre-listening analysis is analysing the speaker. If the listener knows the speaker well, he/she will be able to make appropriate adaptations for better understanding. Is the speaker an expert of the subject, or just a generalist? What are his/her background and specific qualifications that make him/her fit for the presentation? Has the listener ever heard him/her before? Is he/she a native speaker? Answers to these questions will give the listener a fairly good idea of the speaker and help him/her improve.

Predicting

Predicting is a listening strategy for lecture comprehension. It is the process of guessing the information that one expects to receive during a lecture or talk. The listener should be able to think ahead, hypothesise, and predict.

Predicting includes various micro-skills, including the ability to:

- Guess the information that the lecture contains
- Use the title of the lecture/talk/presentation to roughly predict the central theme and the focus of the verbal message
- Scan the use of visual aids in the opening part of the lecture to predict the nature and scope of content
- Identify oral clues used by the speaker

Predicting is the process of guessing the information that one expects to receive during a lecture or talk.

The listener should try to guess the overall content of the speech, i.e. guessing the information that he/she expects to receive. The more he/she is familiar with the content, the more he/she understands the oral message. For example, if he/she is going to listen to a speech by the chief guest at the annual day programme of his/her college, the listener may ask himself/herself the following questions:

1. What is he going to talk about?
2. Is he going to talk about our college?
3. Is he going to tell something that I already know?
4. Is he going to talk about the growth of the college?
5. How long is he going to talk?
6. Will he give academic suggestions to the students of the college?
7. Will he ask questions?

The listener should also develop a positive attitude to the speaker and the topic.

Answers to such questions will help develop the required interest and motivation that are essential for effective listening. The listener should also develop a positive attitude to the speaker and the topic.

Using Background Knowledge

Once the listener has guessed the information that he/she is likely to receive, he/she may recall related information. He/she can pool his/her 'background knowledge' to get a general idea of what he/she is going to listen to. A familiar topic will make him/her more interested in the talk and he/she will actively listen to it, resulting in total comprehension. For example, when going to listen to a lecture on "Information Technology and Communication" if one is using one's background knowledge about information technology, one would find it easy to understand the lecture. Even if the speaker introduces new ideas and concepts, one may not find them too difficult. Moreover, the whole exercise of using background information will provide the necessary motivation essential for an active listener.

Once the listener has guessed the information that he/she is likely to receive, he/she may recall related information.

Intensive Listening

Once the listener has determined his/her purpose, analysed his/her speaker, and used prediction techniques and background knowledge, he/she is ready to listen to the lecture or talk. Most speakers organise the talk into three segments: introduction, body, and conclusion. The listener has to concentrate on each segment to understand the overall meaning, focus, and implication of the talk. The guidelines for this have been given below:

Most speakers organise a talk into three segments: introduction, body, and conclusion.

Listening to the Introduction

- Listen to the opening or introduction of the talk to get answers to the following questions:
 - (a) What is the position, knowledge, background, experience of the speaker?
 - (b) What is his/her credibility?
 - (c) What is the overall purpose of the talk?
 - (d) What is the central idea or theme?
 - (e) What is the overall organisational structure?

- (f) What does the speaker intend to do? (describe, instruct, report, narrate, explain, argue, persuade, illustrate, and so on)
- (g) What are the main points of the talk?
- Concentrate on the visual aids, if used by the speaker.
- Identify the key words or phrases that the speaker might use to emphasise the main points.

Listening to the Body

- As the body of a talk or lecture contains the main message, you should pay attention to every part of the body carefully.
- Concentrate on the verbal signposts in order to recognise the organisation and main points of the oral message.
- Recognise main supporting details of the oral message.
- Concentrate on visual aids such as overhead transparencies, flipcharts, handouts, slides, multimedia visuals, and so on to get a clear idea of the important points of the talk.

Listening to the Conclusion

- Listen to the closing or conclusion of the talk to understand the main themes of the verbal message.
- Recognise the speaker's focus of the talk.
- Concentrate on what the speaker wants the listeners to do, or remember.

Understanding the Links between Different Parts of Speech

The most important aspect of lecture comprehension is identifying the key points of a lecture. In order to recognise key points, we have to understand the links between different parts of speech. This involves recognising listening cues used by the speaker. Every speaker uses various techniques to indicate the relative importance of different parts of information contained in the talk. These techniques include identifying prosodic and syntactic features, oral discourse markers, and transitions.

Every speaker uses various techniques to indicate the relative importance of different parts of information contained in the talk.

Prosodic Features and Syntactic Features

Prosodic features include pauses, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns.

Prosodic features include pauses, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns. A listener needs a proper understanding of English pronunciation and articulation in order to understand these features. The chapter on "Oral Communication and Speaking Techniques" in Part Three of this book contains a detailed discussion on these topics.

Syntactic features comprise grammatical structures such as subordinate clauses, noun complements, and so on. Comprehending these syntactic structures during listening demands a fairly good understanding of English grammar. Listeners should concentrate on these features to get the correct meaning of the message.

Syntactic features comprise grammatical structures such as subordinate clauses, noun complements, and so on.

Oral Discourse Markers

Oral discourse markers include signal phrases, logical connectors, and transitional signals.

Signal Phrases

Lecturers and speakers use specific words and phrases to indicate major transitions and emphasis in their lectures. As illustrated in Table 6.2, they help the listener understand the links between different parts of the talk.

Lecturers and speakers use specific words and phrases to indicate major transitions and emphasis in their lectures.

TABLE 6.2 Signal Phrases

<i>Purpose of the Speaker</i>	<i>Signal Phrases</i>
Introducing a topic	Today, I'd like to talk about..., What I'm going to discuss is..., The main point of the discussion today is..., To begin with..., In the first place..., My first point is ..., At the start let me say that..., First I'd like to discuss..., Today I'd like to describe...'
Developing an idea	If we critically examine the situation..., As you know that..., The most significant point is..., The best solution to the problem is..., It is significant to note that..., Let's try to understand it..., It's very interesting to note..., This means that..., As you are aware..., The crucial factor is..., The point to note is,
Emphasising a point	I am sure you'll agree with me..., No one can deny the fact that..., I'd like to emphasise..., The next point is crucial to my argument...,
Contrasting several ideas	In contrast, On the other hand..., If we make a comparative analysis..., On the contrary.
Showing transition of ideas	The next important point is..., The second significant aspect is..., Let's consider another factor ..., My next point is...,
Concluding	Finally, At the end..., That's all I wanted to discuss..., I'd like to sum up..., I'd like to conclude..., In conclusion...,

Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals

As illustrated in Table 6.3, speakers use logical connectors to show logical organisation and rhetorical features of a talk.

TABLE 6.3 Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals

<i>Purpose of the Speaker</i>	<i>Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals</i>
Adding a point	Moreover, in addition, Next, Then, Furthermore, Second, Finally
Comparing	Similarly, Likewise, In the same way
Making a contrast	In contrast, By comparison, In comparison, However, Nevertheless, If we make a comparative analysis
Showing segmentation	Right, OK, Well, All right, And, Now, That's fine, That's all, etc.
Exemplifying	In other words, For example, For instance, Take for example
Temporal	Eventually, At that time, For the time being, As, After, Before, Since, Till, Until, When, As soon as, By the time
Explaining/Showing cause and effect	Therefore, Thus, So, That is why, As, Because, Hence, For that reason, As a result, As a consequence, Consequently
Showing emphasis	Obviously, As you can see, Infact, As you know, Actually, Naturally, Of course, You see

Other Transitions

Apart from oral discourse markers, speakers might use several other transitions to lead listeners from one idea to another. The following are some such transitions:

- **Visual transitions:** Some speakers may add a visual between regular visual aids in order to give a “visual” transition. Such visuals might be an important clue to understand that part of the talk or presentation.
- **Repetitions:** Speakers may use the same words, phrases, or ideas twice to initiate a transition.
- **Questions:** Speakers may ask a question to make a transition.
- **Sequence:** A speaker may use sequence or point-by-point description to indicate transition (for example, There are two important considerations...The first one is.. The second one is).
- **Flashback:** A speaker may use a flashback technique to start a new point (for example, Do you recall my first observation).
- **Pauses:** Some speakers effectively use pausing as a transition technique because they give the listeners time to think.

Progress Check 3

1. Which of the following is not an effective listening strategy for lecture comprehension?

- (a) Audience analysis
 - (b) Predicting
 - (c) Use of background knowledge
 - (d) Recognising key phrases
 - (e) Concentrating on speaker's appearance
 - (f) Understanding the visual aids
 - (g) Recognising minor points of the oral message
 - (h) Analysing the situation
 - (i) Speaker analysis
 - (j) Understanding all the illustrations
 - (k) Identifying the key points of a lecture
 - (l) Concentrating on the verbal signposts in order to recognise the organisation
 - (m) Determining the purpose of listening
 - (n) Recognising the focus of the talk
 - (o) Understanding the links between different parts of speech
 - (p) Recognising listening cues
-

6.2.5 Team Listening

In view of the widespread use of oral communication in team management and decision making, there can be little doubt about the value of good listening skills in achieving group communicative goals. When we take part in a group communicative situation, we cannot contribute to the stated purposes of the communication unless we are listening properly. By participating as an active listener, we may meet a personal need to contribute to the accomplishments of the goals of a group activity. Moreover, active participation as a listener in a group and its discussions and deliberations serves the group-centered needs of an individual. Finally, active listening meets the ego-centered needs of listeners by enhancing their status as successful “communicators”.

Listening in teams is more difficult than listening to structured talks and well-organised lectures. While we listen to a talk, we get information in an organised and structured form. Understanding the main points is not difficult because the speaker may repeat them several times during the talk. The use of signposts and visual aids also make comprehension easier. On the other hand, when we listen to deliberations during a group discussion, meeting, or team interactions, we get information in a disorganised and unclear form. There are no repetitions of points, no visual aids to clarify points and improve comprehension, no verbal signposts to indicate organisation and main points in an oral message. It is, therefore, important that we take extra precautions during team listening.

The following suggestions are designed to help improve team listening skills.

Active listening meets the ego-centered needs of listeners by enhancing their status as successful “communicators”. Listening in teams is more difficult than listening to structured talks and well-organised lectures.

Avoid Distractions

There are two kinds of distractions that might disrupt the listening process—surrounding noise and physical disturbances, and disturbed state of mind.

There are two kinds of distractions that might disrupt the listening process. The first of these distractions result from surrounding noise and physical disturbances. In order to avoid these external distractions during the process of listening, you have to ensure that all channels are free of noise during the time of communication. The second type of distractions may result from your disturbed state of mind. The best way to control these distractions is to avoid team listening while you are emotionally disturbed. However, if you cannot avoid listening, you should focus 100% on what other members of the team are talking about.

Avoid Negative Non-verbal Signals

Using negative non-verbal signals during group communication is not only rude but also against team spirit as it may lead to misunderstanding and mistrust between team members. Do not use non-verbal signals to show disagreement, boredom, and lack of comprehension. It is better to express these feelings verbally. Avoid using fingers or negative head shaking to say ‘no’, or ‘rolling eyes’ to indicate that the speaker is a fool, or negative hand gestures to show that you disagree.

Do not use non-verbal signals to show disagreement, boredom, and lack of comprehension.

It is impolite to interrupt a person who is speaking as it shows lack of respect and creates misunderstanding.

Don't Interrupt

It is impolite to interrupt a person who is speaking as it shows lack of respect and creates misunderstanding. You may have something important to say or may be very eager to give a quick reply or opinion but it is not fair to interrupt the speaker. It makes you overeager and careless. Good team spirit demands better manners.

Be Involved

In order to be an effective team listener, do not just absorb the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement but be alert and pay close attention while listening to your team members. Make conscious efforts with concentration, involvement and responsibility to improve your listening effectiveness as a team member.

Make conscious efforts with concentration, involvement and responsibility to improve your listening effectiveness as a team member.

Recognise Important Facts

It is important to recognize important facts during team listening because team members might express them informally in a casual manner. You have to obtain relevant information and identify the main ideas and supporting details. Although you have to listen carefully to everything that your team members say, you need to filter the information to identify the overall purpose, the central theme and the main focus of what they are saying.

It is important to recognize important facts during team listening because team members might express them informally in a casual manner.

Good team members avoid making subjective observations while listening to each other and avoid giving judgements on what they listen.

Be Objective

Good team members avoid making subjective observations while listening to each other. Being objective will help you as well as the team members in getting a clear picture of each other's ideas and feelings. Also, avoid giving judgements on what you listen. Expressions such as "I think your reasoning is inappropriate", or "I do not understand your attitude" are judgmental and should be avoided.

Make Notes

Make notes to retain and use the information that you receive during team listening. Do not rely on your memory. Refer to the next section for learning effective note taking techniques.

Progress Check 4

1. Which of the following listening practices will make you a better team listener?

- (a) Using negative non-verbal signals
- (b) Controlling external and internal distractions
- (c) Becoming actively involved
- (d) Listening between the lines
- (e) Interrupting
- (f) Asking questions
- (g) Rephrasing
- (h) Taking notes
- (i) Being subjective
- (j) Relaxing during lag time

6.2.6 Listening and Note Taking

While listening to a lecture or a talk, or to a team member during a group discussion or meeting, one needs to remember the information so that it can be used in some other form. It is better not to trust only one's memory, and one should take notes while listening. Taking notes helps one to understand the points clearly and keep a record for future reference. Even if the facts are easy to remember, they should be jotted down for clarity.

Note taking may be defined as the process of writing down quickly, briefly, and clearly the important points of a lecture, speech, presentation, or any structured verbal message. It involves summarising and paraphrasing the verbal message.

Techniques of Note Taking

Taking notes while listening to lectures and talks is an important academic activity. Learning effective note-taking techniques is essential because it is more challenging than making reading notes. While reading a text, you can reread several times for better comprehension and notes can be made leisurely. However, this is not possible in note taking because the speaker is not going to repeat his/her points for your convenience.

The four steps of note taking include listening, filtering, paraphrasing, and noting.

It is important that you avoid writing down everything you hear. You have to carefully filter the information that you receive and adopt a strategy that enables you to understand the lecture quickly and make appropriate notes. Effective note-taking strategies are essential. Note taking includes four simple steps, i.e., listening, filtering, paraphrasing, and noting.

Listen

- Follow the 10 thumb rules for good listening and apply active listening techniques for better comprehension.
- Carefully listen to the verbal message in order to identify its purpose and scope.
- Identify different modes and styles of delivery (i.e., reading style, conversational style, informal style, rhetorical style, and so on).
- Deduce meanings of words and phrases from their context and infer relationships.
- Recognise key terms related to the subject/topic of the lecture.
- Recognise function of stress and intonation to signal information structure.
- Recognise function of non-verbal cues as markers of emphasis and attitude.
- Interpret the oral message with reference to oral conventions followed by the speaker.

Filter

- Do not try to write everything.
- Filter the information received.
- Concentrate on verbal signposts to recognise the organisation and main points in an oral message.
- Identify relationships among units within the speech (i.e., main points, supporting points, minor points, generalisations, hypotheses, illustrations, and so on).
- Look out for key phrases and signal words.
- Identify the role of discourse markers.
- Identify the main points.

Paraphrase

- After identifying the core information, rephrase suitably.
- Use appropriate words and phrases to express the central idea, main points, and main supporting details.
- Do not use full sentences.

Note

- After restructuring and rephrasing the core information, jot them down.
- Use appropriate reduction techniques such as abbreviations and symbols to save time.
- Use subordinating techniques and a suitable method of sequencing, i.e. numerals and numbers, decimalisation, and so on.
- Use note cards or notebooks to record notes.

Progress Check 5

1. Study the following statements about note making, and mark True or False against each of them.
 - (a) Note taking refers to the process of making reading notes.
 - (b) Note taking does not involve paraphrasing.
 - (c) The act of decoding in note taking involves recognition of false starts, pauses, intonation, and rhythm patterns.
 - (d) While taking notes, the listener should write everything that he/she hears in the lecture.
 - (e) The listener must adopt a careful strategy that enables him/her to understand the lecture.
 - (f) Every speaker follows certain oral conventions.
 - (g) Identifying key points of a lecture does not involve recognising signal words and phrases.
 - (h) Lecturers and speakers never try to indicate major transitions in their lectures.
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Exercise

1. Answer the following questions:
 - (a) What is listening comprehension?
 - (b) Discuss some positive listening practices.
 - (c) Differentiate between active and passive listening.
 - (d) What are the different strategies for lecture comprehension?
 - (e) What are the factors that make an effective team listener?
 - (f) What is the process of taking notes while listening?
2. Listen to the radio for half an hour. Evaluate and scan the information that you receive for topics of interest to you. Match topics against your own interest and make mental notes. Write a summary of what you have listened after one hour.
3. Listen to the weather report on television. Concentrate on the weather forecast about your area in order to decide appropriate clothes to wear during the day.
4. Listen to a panel discussion on television. Listen to what the speakers are saying, also how they are saying it (for example, is he or she surprised, annoyed, angry, upset, confused, relaxed, tense, pleased, confident, nervous, and so on). Prepare a brief report on the discussion mentioning the important points of discussion.
5. Listen to a 30-minute television news report. Use the listening techniques discussed in this chapter. Then, write a summary of the news highlighting significant events, incidents, and persons in the news.

6. Listen to a specific long dialogue in a television serial or film. Concentrate on the structural, syntactic, discourse, semantic, and phonological clues. Understand the explicit as well as implicit meaning of the expressions used in the dialogues. Reconstruct the dialogue.
7. Form a group of four or five students and conduct a group discussion on any of the topics mentioned below. You may elect a group leader to conduct the discussion. Listen to the views of each team member and write a summary of the discussion, adding your input to the discussion.
 - (a) Reducing IIM fees by the government was a retrograde step
 - (b) Human cloning should be banned
 - (c) Coalition politics is to stay in India
 - (d) Unemployment problem
 - (e) Controlling environmental pollution
8. For one week concentrate on your listening practices in the following communicative situations:
 - (a) Informal conversations
 - (b) Classroom interactions
 - (c) Tutorials and practicals
 - (d) Student-teacher consultations
 - (e) Seminars and workshops
 - (f) Technical presentations
 - (g) Academic discussions

Now identify some of your bad listening practices and discuss them with your English language teacher. Ask him/her to suggest ways to improve your listening habits.
9. Listen to any lecture in your college. Take notes while you listen. Apply effective note taking strategies and rephrase your notes properly. After a few days, reconstruct the lecture on the basis of your notes. Show the reconstructed lecture to the teacher who gave the lecture, and request him to comment on it.
10. Listen to a 30-minute detective serial on TV along with a friend. Follow plot development, logical argument, and visual information about the content. Listen to the dialogues carefully, analyse the climax, and write brief notes on the following:
 - (a) the plot of the serial
 - (b) the main characters of the serial
 - (c) justification of the climax in the serial

Discuss your notes with the friend and ask him/her to comment on the accuracy of your descriptions.

Key to Progress Check

Progress Check 1

1. The following table summarises listening comprehension skills:

Listening comprehension skills	
Literal skills	Sound recognition
• Recognising sounds and sound patterns accurately • Recognising the way sounds combine to form syllables and utterances	
	Word recognition

- Recognising words accurately
 - Understanding the definitions of the words being used
 - Recognising the way words are used in context
 - Identifying discourse markers and attention signals
 - Accent recognition
 - Recognising stress and intonation patterns
 - Scanning
 - Locating specific information in a conversation or speech
 - Prediction
 - Guessing information
 - Comprehending
 - Identifying theme or central idea
 - Identifying main ideas
 - Identifying supporting details, illustrations, and examples
- Critical and analytical skills
- Critical skills
- Distinguishing between
- facts and opinions
 - relevant and irrelevant information
 - explicit and implicit information
 - examples and ideas
- Attitude analysis
- Understanding the speaker's intention
 - Identifying a speaker's attitude
 - Evaluating a speaker's attitude
- Inferential skills
- Drawing inferences and conclusions
-

Progress Check 2

(a), (c), (d) and (h)

Progress Check 3

(e), (g) and (j)

Progress Check 4

(b), (c), (d), (f), (g) and (h)

Progress Check 5

1. (a) False (b) False (c) True (d) False (e) True
(g) True (f) False